

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1079

By Love

A RESOLUTION to honor Alkebu-Lan Images Bookstore on the occasion of its fortieth anniversary and to commemorate National Black Bookstore Day.

WHEREAS, the rich cultural heritage of the United States is deeply shaped by Black storytellers, scholars, publishers, and entrepreneurs who have preserved, published, and shared knowledge through literature and community institutions; and

WHEREAS, throughout history, African Americans have made significant contributions to the culture, economy, and social fabric of our country and have played an integral role in shaping the independent bookstore industry, even though Black-owned bookstores represent less than eight percent of all booksellers in the United States; and

WHEREAS, Black-owned bookstores have long served as vital institutions for education, activism, cultural expression, civic dialogue, and economic empowerment, especially during periods when mainstream institutions excluded or ignored Black voices; and

WHEREAS, since the 19th century, Black visionary entrepreneurs have established bookstores that became sacred spaces for intellectual growth, cultural preservation, and political engagement, including David Ruggles' bookstore (1834), George Young's Young's Book Exchange (1915), Lewis Michaux's African National Memorial Bookstore (circa 1932), Marshall's Music & Bookstore (est. 1938), Hakim's Bookstore (1959), Marcus Books (1960), Liberation Bookstore (1967), and Hue-Man Bookstore & Café (1984); and

WHEREAS, from the 1960s through the 1990s, Black-owned bookstores served as epicenters of community organizing, education, artistic expression, and historic preservation within African American communities nationwide; and

WHEREAS, the number of Black-owned bookstores declined significantly over recent decades—from more than 325 in 1999 to just 54 in 2014, many operating under substantial financial strain; and

WHEREAS, in recent years, renewed national attention to racial equity and community investment has contributed to a resurgence of Black-owned bookstores, with nearly 300 operating across the United States today; and

WHEREAS, Georgia "Mother Rose" West founded Underground Books in Sacramento, California, where it became a treasured gathering place for literature, learning, and community, and her legacy inspired the establishment of National Black Bookstore Day in her honor; and

WHEREAS, the National Association of Black Bookstores works to promote literacy, amplify Black voices, and strengthen the sustainability and visibility of Black-owned bookstores nationwide; and

WHEREAS, the National Association of Black Bookstores has identified Tennessee's Alkebu-Lan Images Bookstore, founded in 1986 by Yusef Harris, as the fourth-oldest Black-owned bookstore in the United States; today, Jordan Harris owns and operates the bookstore; and

WHEREAS, Alkebu-Lan Images Bookstore has served for four decades as a cornerstone of Black cultural life in Nashville by hosting author events and community gatherings, promoting youth literacy, partnering with local schools and nonprofit organizations, supporting local writers and entrepreneurs, and contributing to the economic vitality of the Historic Jefferson Street corridor and surrounding neighborhoods; and

WHEREAS, April 1, 2026, marks the fortieth anniversary of Alkebu-Lan Images Bookstore, an important milestone in Black-owned entrepreneurship and cultural preservation in Nashville and the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, recognizing National Black Bookstore Day each year on April 7 provides an opportunity to honor the legacy, resilience, and ongoing contributions of Black-owned bookstores locally and nationwide; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor Alkebu-Lan Images Bookstore on the occasion of its fortieth anniversary, as we join with the National Association of Black Bookstores in its celebration of April 7, 2026, as National Black Bookstore Day.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.